

Every project has a name, an owner, a number and a limit.

Not a cost-cutting programme. The spending control that every other budget line already has, applied to the one where the decisions are made daily by people who never see the invoice.



Named

One identifier per project, across every resource it touches.



Owned

A named person who signs off the budget and answers the alert.



Measured

A cost per customer or per transaction, refreshed daily.



Limited

A ceiling that binds before the invoice does.

WHY NOW

This is where the industry is already going

FinOps Foundation, State of FinOps 2026 (n ≈ 1,500 practitioners worldwide).

78%

of FinOps practices now report
into the CTO/CIO organization

up 18 points since 2023

98%

of practices now manage AI
spend as a core operating cost

SaaS 90% · licensing 64% · data centre
48%

#3

governance ranks above
optimization in 2026 priorities

behind only AI cost management and
AI-driven efficiency

What it means for this organization

Cost control has stopped being a finance report and become a technology capability — which puts it on this desk. The industry's own conclusion is that attacking waste after the fact has hit diminishing returns; the returns now come from ownership, governance and scope.

STEP ONE — SEE IT

One number per project, with an owner on it

Two things have to be true: the cost can be traced to someone, and the project is priced whole.

Trace it to an owner

- 1 Tag at creation**
Five tags, enforced by policy. Untagged means undeployed.
- 2 Allocate the spend**
Target under 5% unallocated, reported weekly.
- 3 Show teams their own numbers**
Four to six weeks before anything is charged.
- 4 Divide by the unit**
Cost per customer, per order, per conversation.

Price the project whole

An AI feature is quoted at its token cost. It runs on a stack that bills every month regardless.

- Model / tokens**
the line everyone quotes
- Compute, databases, cache**
app services, SQL, Redis, queues
- Storage, network, observability**
backups, egress, log ingestion

Every layer bills whether or not the model is called.

One ApplicationID across every resource a project touches. The review then sees a single number with a single owner — and the model's share becomes a ratio anyone can argue with, rather than the headline.

STEP TWO — CONTROL IT

Two moments, and only one of them is cheap

At design, changing a cost is a conversation. After deployment, it is a migration.

AT DESIGN — SHIFT LEFT

FinOps sits in the design and intake conversation, understanding what the project needs before the architecture is set.

- **Priced options**
Two or three costed before one is chosen.
- **A cost target**
Recorded beside the latency and availability targets.
- **Enforced in the pipeline**
Tagging and budget rules as policy, not paperwork.

AT RUNTIME — GUARDRAILS

Controls that act on spend already running, ordered by how fast each one takes effect.

- **Quotas and rate limits**
Seconds. The only control that stops spend in progress.
- **Alerts routed to owners**
Minutes on usage data. Never a page on a budget number.
- **Budget thresholds**
Notify, review, gate — against the elapsed month.

“A cost alert cannot save you from a runaway job — by the time the billing data moves, the money is spent.”

WHAT WE ARE ASKING FOR

Ninety days, and two decisions today

Weeks 1-4

Name it

Tag taxonomy published and enforced. An owner recorded for every application above a spend floor.

Weeks 5-8

See it

One number per project, showback to every team, and cost in the design review.

Weeks 9-12

Hold it

Quotas on the largest workloads, alerts routed to owners, monthly review with finance.

How we will know it is working

Allocation coverage	under 5%
Time to attribute a spike	hours, not days
Cost per unit	trending, per project

Decisions needed today

1. Who owns the tagging standard, and by when?
2. Are we willing to have a limit that blocks?

No new headcount and no platform purchase in this plan. A tooling decision comes later, and only if allocation cannot be fixed at source.